they had to converse with a Brahmin they had to observe the correct distance, but also cover their mouths with their hands, remain bowed and not speak of themselves in the first person.

Then at some point in the late eighteenth century it was further decided that a number of these now well-established caste prohibitions should be taxable – that is to say, a prohibition could be avoided by paying a tax on it. It has been calculated that very soon after the start of the nineteenth century the ordinary people of Travancore were being required to pay as many as a hundred petty taxes, ranging from head tax, hut tax, marriage tax and taxes on the tools of one's trade to taxes on the family cow, goat or dog, wearing jewellery, staging festivals, and even growing moustaches. But most iniquitous of all was what became known as the breast tax, *mulakkaram*.

As noted by Nieuhof, Buchanan and other observers of the Indian social scene, both sexes in South India had since time immemorial limited their clothing to *lungi*s, *kaili*s or *mundu*s in the form of waist-cloths secured with a belt, with the more wealthy adding shawls on occasion, and jewellery being the key to demonstrating high status. But with the settling along the Malabar coast of Arab Muslims (the Mappilas), and the growth of their community in parallel with the Syrian Christians (known as Nazrani, or Nazarenes), the women of these two communities took to covering their upper bodies in accordance with the demands of their religions. Catholic and Protestant Christian conversions from the sixteenth century added to their numbers, and soon it became the norm for women of higher and middle social status to cover up. But when *mulakkaram* was written into law in Travancore it became obligatory for every Hindu woman of low caste or without caste to bare her breasts in public or pay the required tax. This was increasingly resented, not as an affront to modesty but because it very publicly defined someone's low status.